PLACE Making Team Aboriculture

Development Management Consultation Response

Date: 12 November 2024

Reference:	Site:	Proposal:	Case Officer:
S/RES/24/0947-2	Parcels R6 And R7 Land North Of A420 Swindon	A reserved matters application (access, appearance, layout, scale and landscaping) for 137 dwellings and associated infrastructure - Reserved Matters from previous outline permission S/OUT/13/1555.	Barry James
Summary of response			
		No Comment/No Objection ☐ Conditions required ☐ Objection - changes required ☒ Objection in principle ☐	
Executive Summary			

Full Comments

Further to my memorandum of 23 September 2024, the applicant has submitted an arboricultural method statement prepared by FPCR (dated October 2024), a cross-sectional plan of various tree pit details presented by IDP (drg no. : IDPL LA5979-BP-404) and an amended suite of soft landscape proposals (IDPL LA5979-BP-401, 2 and 3 - all rev C).

I previously raised several points relating to potential conflicts with existing trees In the absence of any tree or hedge data highlighting, in particular, proposed work in the vicinity of T49 and H34, H35, T51 and H34. The recently submitted arboricultural information includes a survey and assessment of the trees and hedges and a tree protection plan, with enlarged extracts focusing on the locations of proposed 'no-dig' construction (T41 and T45) or the where arboricultural supervision is required (G29). I note that the incursions within the root protection areas of T41 and T45 are for the purposes of bearing a pedestrian footpath and, if constructed as set out in section 9.5, is likely to avoid any long-term impact on the roots beneath. In respect of G29, however, its RPA will be breached to the east (albeit under supervision) by more than a third (4.5m) without any contingency for the discovery of roots. Furthermore, the use of a mechanised excavator is promoted with a caveat that the excavation depth is achieved by undertaking a

series of shallow scrapes across the RPA. This is nonsensical because there is no alternative proposed if roots are discovered (or are just beneath the area excavated), in which case the parking space and footpath will result in the subsequent exposure and severance of roots and compaction of the ground. The parking space should be repositioned to a location wholly beyond the root protection area.

As regards the particular tree issues I raised previously, I acknowledge that T49 is to be removed on the grounds of condition and that construction of the parking areas to the east of H35 could be undertaken without detriment to the long-term health of the hedge. Construction adjacent to T51, on the other hand, is within its root protection area. The survey data records the stem measurements (from which the RPA formula is derived) as 350 and 290mm. The upper part of the stem bifurcation is higher than 1.5m and, consequently, the stem should be measured at its narrowest point beneath the fork. I have visited the site and measured the tree to calculate the correct root protection area and arrived at an RPA of 209m^2. This requires the radial distance of protection to extend 8.16m from the tree, rather than the 5.2m indicated on the tree protection plan. Correcting the RPA precludes the construction of the dwelling as proposed within plot 73 (previously numbered as plot 75). This will need to be addressed at this stage.

The matter of the installation of the surface water pipe through H34 at the southern boundary has not been addressed within the tree report. The sensitivity on this boundary is acute as there is extensive vegetation, plus a ditch, and the methodology needs to be understood before consent is granted.

The landscape drawings indicate that T49 is to be retained and accommodated into the scheme. This contradicts the tree protection plans and requires clarification and amendment to the landscape drawing, given its condition. The concerns I raised in respect of specific parking bays not complying with the coded requirements for tree provision have been alleviated by amendments to the layout in respect of plots 63 – 84. Similarly, removal of the parking spaces along the primary street have led to an arrangement for proposed trees that better resembles the requirement of the design code.

I previously commented on the limited gateway aspect where the primary street enters the site to the southeast. The amended plans no longer show the retention of the fallen Willow (T46), but have also removed the row of Malus proposed to the west. The coding required this to be a landscape-led feature and I will defer to my landscape architect colleagues in respect of whether this has been satisfactorily achieved.

The presentation of the tree pit details, alongside the extent of below surface tree pits being identified on the landscape plans, indicates how the lifetime soil requirements will be facilitated. The available soil volume for the nine locations for G2 400 rootspace installation should be indicated and, as amendments are necessary to the landscape plan, this could be included on a revised Soft Landscape Proposals General Arrangement plan. Additionally, the positions of the engineered tree pits should be marked on either the

Highways layout or the engineering layout as their construction has direct implications for the adjoining footway/carriageway construction.